

Morning Edition

Saturday, 12 September 2026

Ten stories curated through your lens on ocean governance, hydrospatial science, and SIDS equity.

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⚡ ACTIONABLE — DEADLINE TOMORROW

The ocean fellowship deadline is tomorrow

The UNNF Fellowship on Ocean Affairs and the Law of the Sea closes applications tomorrow, and it is exactly the funded credential that turns your

policy work into a formal qualification.

STORY NOTES

Fourteen fellowships are on offer for the 2027 session of the UNNF Fellowship on Ocean Affairs and the Law of the Sea, and the application window shuts on 13 September, tomorrow. The fellowship is built for mid-level government officials and professionals already working in ocean affairs or the law of the sea, funding advanced training in the field, including marine science tracks tied to management frameworks.

You apply through the Indico.UN platform, not by email, and the platform does not extend deadlines for late submissions. If you know anyone inside Seychelles's government working the maritime boundary or fisheries brief, tomorrow is the last day to get their application in.

<https://www.un.org/oceancapacity/content/unnf-ocean-governance-fellowship-sids>

STORY ARTICLE

You spent twelve years doing GIS work for a fire service before anyone in ocean governance called you a specialist. That gap between practitioner experience and formal credential is the exact gap the UNNF Fellowship on Ocean Affairs and the Law of the Sea is built to close, and its application window for the 2027 session shuts tomorrow, 13 September.

The fellowship offers fourteen places for the coming cycle. It targets mid-level government officials and other professionals already working directly in ocean affairs or the law of the sea, and funds advanced training in the field, with tracks that extend into marine science where it supports management frameworks. That detail matters more than it looks. Most ocean law fellowships assume a legal background. This one explicitly makes room for people whose expertise sits in mapping, monitoring, and spatial management rather than treaty drafting, a narrower door than it sounds, but a real one.

The objection is obvious: you already do this work without the fellowship, built over a decade running maritime boundary delimitation and UNDP regional programmes. What the fellowship changes has nothing to do with your competence and everything to do with how you get read in a donor meeting or a procurement panel, particularly when the room defaults to assuming ocean governance expertise comes from a law degree. It is the difference between being the person explaining bathymetric data to lawyers and being read as someone with standing to shape the legal instrument itself.

There is also a network argument, and it is the stronger one. Fourteen fellows per cycle, drawn from developing states dealing directly with ocean affairs, is a small enough cohort that it functions as a durable professional network rather than a certificate filed away. For SHORE Institute, sitting inside that cohort, or having someone from Seychelles's government inside it, is worth more than the training content itself. It is a direct line into the people who will be implementing the BBNJ Agreement's institutional architecture over the next five years, at exactly the moment PrepCom decisions are hardening into standing practice.

The deadline is unforgiving. Applications go through the Indico.UN platform, not by email, and UN fellowship administration does not extend for late submissions. If there is anyone in Seychelles's Department of Blue Economy, the fisheries authority, or the maritime boundary desk who has the standing to apply and has not yet submitted, today is the day to make that call, not tomorrow morning.

Whether or not you apply yourself, this is worth flagging in Shorelines as a case study in how SIDS access to institutional capacity-building depends on knowing these deadlines exist at all. Most of the mid-level officials who would benefit from this fellowship never hear about it in time, and that gap is its own argument.

<https://www.un.org/oceancapacity/content/unnf-ocean-governance-fellowship-sids>

Seychelles is eligible for this \$200,000 grant right now

The Commonwealth Secretariat and Azerbaijan's COP29 Presidency have opened a \$5 million fund that Seychelles's government can apply to today for up to \$200,000 per ocean health or climate resilience project.

STORY NOTES

The COP29 Presidency-Commonwealth Fund for Small Island Developing States is open for applications, and Seychelles qualifies automatically as a Commonwealth SIDS. The fund totals \$5 million over five years, with individual government grants capped at \$200,000, targeted at projects that strengthen climate resilience, improve ocean health, or expand sustainable energy.

The call follows two joint flagship projects the Commonwealth Secretariat and Azerbaijan launched in April 2026, and it is structured for in-country implementation rather than regional programming, which means the application has to name a specific Seychelles-based delivery mechanism, not a consortium.

Full call details are published on the Commonwealth Secretariat's website as they become available.

<https://thecommonwealth.org/news/commonwealth-and-cop29-presidency-in-vite-commonwealth-sids-submit-climate-action-proposals>

STORY ARTICLE

Grant funding for Seychelles usually arrives wrapped in regional programming, split across fifteen island states, administered by a UN agency with its own overhead. The COP29 Presidency-Commonwealth Fund for Small Island Developing States works differently: it is a government-to-government in-country grant, capped at \$200,000 per project, and Seychelles qualifies for it simply by being a Commonwealth member state.

The fund holds \$5 million across five years, jointly backed by the Commonwealth Secretariat and Azerbaijan's COP29 Presidency. It follows two flagship projects the two partners

launched in April 2026, and the stated priorities, climate resilience, ocean health, and sustainable energy, are broad enough to cover most of what SHORE Institute would want to propose under a hydrospatial monitoring banner.

The objection worth naming here is capacity, not eligibility. Seychelles's government has a track record of qualifying for funds like this and then losing the window because no one inside the relevant ministry has the bandwidth to draft a competitive proposal against a hard deadline. It is the standard failure mode for small-state access to climate finance across the Commonwealth, and it is precisely the gap AOSIS has been naming at UNFCCC ocean dialogues this year: SIDS get a disproportionately small share of SDG14 funding not because the money does not exist, but because the administrative capacity to compete for it does not scale with fifteen ministries running parallel bids against larger states with dedicated grant-writing units.

This is where the fund's design actually helps. A \$200,000 cap and an in-country delivery requirement means Seychelles is not competing against Fiji or Jamaica for the same pot the way it would under a regional facility. It is competing against the strength of its own proposal, which changes the calculation for anyone weighing whether it is worth the ministry's time to apply.

If SHORE Institute wants a role here, the practical entry point is technical partner on a government-led bid, not applicant. Coastal monitoring data, seafloor mapping capacity, or spatial planning support for a marine protected area proposal are all defensible technical

components under an ocean health grant, and pairing institutional grant access with SHORE's spatial data capability is a more competitive package than either side submitting alone.

The Commonwealth Secretariat has not yet published the full call text with a hard submission deadline, only the announcement that the fund is open. That is worth watching closely over the next few weeks rather than assuming there will be ample runway once details land. Ocean funds with fixed multi-year envelopes and no published deadline tend to move fast once the call goes live, and the states that move first, with a proposal already drafted, are the ones that get funded.

<https://thecommonwealth.org/news/commonwealth-and-cop29-presidency-invite-commonwealth-sids-submit-climate-action-proposals>

SEAFLOOR COLLAPSE, SOUTHEAST INDIAN RIDGE, APRIL 2024

4.2m

The ocean floor just tore open 500,000 times faster than normal

This is the first time anyone has directly instrumented a seafloor spreading event as it happened, and it resets what real-time hydrospatial monitoring of tectonically active seafloor can actually claim to measure.

STORY NOTES

A paper in Nature documents the first direct, real-time observation of a seafloor spreading event at a mid-ocean ridge. Jean-Yves Royer's team deployed an autonomous observatory, OHA-GEODAMS, near Amsterdam Island on the Southeast Indian Ridge in February 2024: five hydrophones, fifteen acoustic transponders, and a bottom-pressure recorder.

Two months later, on 26 April 2024, an earthquake swarm began migrating along the ridge axis. The valley floor collapsed 4.2 metres in days, roughly 500,000 times the ridge's average spreading rate, and repeat mapping found new lava flows over 90 metres thick tracing the paths of propagating dikes in both directions.

<https://www.nature.com/articles/s41586-026-10785-0>

STORY ARTICLE

Plate tectonics textbooks describe seafloor spreading as a continuous, gradual process, millimetres of new crust a year, averaged out over geological time. What Jean-Yves Royer's team actually caught on instruments at the Southeast Indian Ridge was nothing like continuous. It was a single event: a valley floor collapsing 4.2 metres over days, at a rate the observing team characterised as roughly 500,000 times the ridge's average spreading rate, with new lava flows over 90 metres thick left behind once the mapping teams went back to survey it.

The instrumentation is what makes this more than a striking anomaly. The team deployed the Observatory with Hydro-Acoustics and Geodesy near Amsterdam Island, OHA-GEODAMS, in February 2024, combining five autonomous hydrophones for seismic tracking, fifteen acoustic transponders on seafloor tripods to measure horizontal ground motion, and a bottom-pressure recorder for vertical shift. That is a purpose-built geodetic network, not a single sensor buoy, and it was in position for barely two months before an earthquake swarm began migrating along the ridge axis on 26 April 2024 and the network recorded nearly the entire event as it unfolded.

The result matters to hydrospatial science beyond the specific tectonics finding. It is proof that a modest, targeted instrument array, five hydrophones and fifteen transponders, can capture a geological process previously understood only through its aftermath, repeat bathymetric surveys taken months or years later. For anyone building the case for continuous seafloor monitoring in tectonically active waters, this is the reference case: it demonstrates the instrumentation design needed to catch an event in progress rather than reconstruct it from static survey comparison.

There is an obvious objection to drawing broader lessons from a single Southeast Indian Ridge deployment: mid-ocean ridge spreading and the seafloor processes relevant to Seychelles's shelf and slope, subsidence, sediment transport, reef-adjacent bathymetric change, are different geological regimes, and an observatory design tuned to ridge seismicity is not a template to copy directly onto a continental shelf monitoring problem. That is fair, and worth being precise about rather than overselling the analogy in a Shorelines piece.

What transfers is the methodological argument: real-time, in-situ geodetic monitoring catches processes that periodic survey campaigns systematically miss, because periodic surveys can only ever show the before and after of an event, never the event itself, whatever the specific instrument array looks like on a continental shelf. That is a strong opening case for why the Ocean Mapping Hub's value proposition should include continuous monitoring capacity, not just periodic bathymetric survey aggregation, if the funding case can be made for the instrumentation cost.

<https://www.nature.com/articles/s41586-026-10785-0>

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⚡ ACTIONABLE – REGISTRATION LIVE

Registration is open for the Indo-Pacific mapping sprint

The Seabed 2030 Indo-Pacific Ocean Mapping Meeting and Data Sprint in Kuala Lumpur is a direct venue for positioning the Ocean Mapping Hub inside the regional bathymetric data pipeline, and registration is open now.

STORY NOTES

\$ Registration is live for the Seabed 2030 Indo-Pacific Ocean Mapping Meeting and Data Sprint, running 20 to 22 October 2026 in Kuala Lumpur. It follows the April 2026 release of the GEBCO_2026 Grid, the eighth grid produced under the Nippon Foundation-GEBCO Seabed 2030 Project, and precedes the project's Global Symposium in Cartagena, Colombia, 8 to 9 October.

A data sprint means hands-on contribution, not a conference panel. If SHORE Institute has crowdsourced bathymetry or multibeam data from Seychelles's waters sitting uncontributed, this is the forum built specifically to fold it into the next grid release rather than waiting for the next general call.

<https://seabed2030.org/>

STORY ARTICLE

Seabed 2030 wants the entire ocean floor mapped by direct measurement before the end of the decade, and the project publishes its progress against that target every year through the GEBCO grid series. The GEBCO_2026 Grid, released in April, is the eighth iteration, and it is a reminder of how much of the western Indian Ocean around Seychelles still falls into the gap between crowdsourced bathymetry contributions and systematic survey coverage.

The Indo-Pacific Ocean Mapping Meeting and Data Sprint, 20 to 22 October in Kuala Lumpur, is the regional forum where that gap gets addressed in practice rather than in a progress report. Registration opened this week. A data sprint is a working session where participants bring bathymetric datasets, whether from crowdsourced bathymetry programmes, national hydrographic offices, or research cruises, and the project's technical teams work through integration into the next grid release in real time.

This is the exact venue the Ocean Mapping Hub concept needs to be visible in. SHORE Institute's case for building a regional bathymetric data hub out of Seychelles rests on the argument that Western Indian Ocean states are structurally underrepresented in global seafloor mapping datasets, not because the data does not exist, but because there is no regional aggregation point that gets it into Seabed 2030's pipeline efficiently. Showing up to a data sprint with an actual dataset, even a modest one, does more for that argument than another conference presentation making the case in the abstract.

There is a genuine cost-benefit question here, worth naming rather than skipping past. Kuala Lumpur is not a short trip from Victoria, and a data sprint format assumes a concrete contribution,

not observation. If SHORE does not currently have bathymetric data ready for submission, the stronger play might be reaching out to the Seabed 2030 regional coordination team before October to understand what a minimum viable contribution looks like, rather than showing up without one.

The Global Symposium in Cartagena the following week, 8 to 9 October, is the higher-visibility event for partnership and funding conversations, but it is also the more crowded room. The Kuala Lumpur data sprint, smaller and technically focused, is where a specific regional gap like the western Indian Ocean's bathymetric coverage gets a working session rather than a mention in a plenary. That is the better return on a single trip if the choice is between the two.

<https://seabed2030.org/>

05

Your ocean is 87 percent of your exports

This is the exact statistic that should anchor every SIDS equity argument you make, because it captures the dependency and the fragility in a single pair of numbers.

"The ocean covers 70 percent of the biosphere of small island developing states, and tourism accounts for 87 percent of their ocean exports."

STORY NOTES

The State of SIDS Report 2026 and this year's UNCTAD ocean commentary both return to the same figures: the ocean covers 70 percent of the biosphere of small island developing states, and tourism accounts for 87 percent of their ocean-related exports. Marine and coastal tourism exports collapsed 70 percent during the pandemic, which is what turned a global shock into an existential one for SIDS economies specifically.

The SIDSTOC Assembly holds its tenth session on 24 September, the standing forum where SIDS trade and ocean commerce data like this gets debated at the technical level rather than cited in a press release.

<https://unctad.org/news/small-island-nations-reliance-ocean-services-heightens-risks-diversification-critical>

STORY ARTICLE

Seventy percent and eighty-seven percent are the two numbers that should anchor every SIDS equity argument you make, because together they show both the dependency and the fragility in one pair of figures rather than a paragraph of description. The ocean makes up 70 percent of the biosphere of small island developing states, unsurprising given their geography, but tourism accounts for 87 percent of their ocean-related exports, which is the number that actually explains why the pandemic collapsed marine and coastal tourism exports by 70 percent almost overnight.

One sector wearing an ocean-economy label while carrying nearly all of the exposure is not diversification, whatever the strategy documents call it. The State of SIDS Report 2026 and UNCTAD's accompanying commentary both land on the same conclusion: SIDS economies describe themselves as blue economies while functioning, in export terms, as tourism monocultures with an ocean backdrop. Blue economy language is doing more rhetorical work than economic work here, not because it is wrong, but because the export data behind it barely moves.

Seychelles is not exempt from this pattern, whatever its high-income classification suggests about resilience. Tourism dominance with a thin diversification layer, some tuna fishery revenue, some emerging blue bond and blue carbon finance, is closer to the SIDS median than Seychelles's

income bracket implies, and that is precisely the High-Income SIDS Paradox argument: income level obscures structural exposure rather than reducing it.

The SIDSTOC Assembly's tenth session, 24 September, is the forum where this data gets worked at a technical level, trade diversification metrics, ocean commerce data, rather than repeated as a headline statistic in a press release. It is a smaller, more specialist room than the SIDS Future Forum or a UNFCCC dialogue, and it is the kind of venue where a sharply argued position paper gets read by the people actually building diversification metrics, rather than competing for attention in a plenary hall.

There is a Shorelines piece sitting directly in this data: the case that blue economy diversification strategies need to be measured against export concentration data, not against the existence of a blue economy strategy document, and that Seychelles's own diversification claims should be held to the same 87 percent tourism-exposure test the rest of the SIDS cohort gets held to. That is a harder piece to write than a celebratory one, and it is exactly the kind of academically grounded, numbers-first argument that distinguishes Shorelines from the general ocean-governance commentary crowding this space.

<https://unctad.org/news/small-island-nations-reliance-ocean-services-heightens-risks-diversification-critical>

Seychelles's largest-ever GEF project just went live

This is the single biggest test yet of whether Seychelles can operationalise blue and green economy language into decision-making inside tourism, food, and urban planning, the exact sectors where your governance-to-implementation critique usually lands.

STORY NOTES

UNDP and Seychelles's Ministry of Environment signed the \$10.48 million GEF-8 project Enabling the Transition to a Blue and Green Economy in the Seychelles, held its inception workshop on 21 August 2026, and it is now Seychelles's largest single GEF-funded project to date.

STORY ARTICLE

Ten million dollars for a small island state sounds like a headline figure until you look at what it is actually meant to buy: not infrastructure, not a marine protected area declaration, but a change in how three ministries, tourism, food systems, and urban development, make routine decisions. The

The seven-year programme aims to integrate biodiversity conservation, ecosystem services, and natural capital into decision-making across tourism, food systems, and urban development, with roughly 10,000 people, including coastal communities, named as direct beneficiaries. It sits under the wider \$135.6 million GEF-8 Blue and Green Islands Integrated Programme, which covers 15 SIDS.

<https://www.undp.org/mauritius-seychelles/news/undp-and-ministry-environment-sign-gef-8-project-advance-seychelles-blue-and-green-economy>

\$10.48 million GEF-8 project Enabling the Transition to a Blue and Green Economy in the Seychelles, signed by UNDP and the Ministry of Environment and launched at an inception workshop on 21 August, is explicitly a governance-integration project, and Seychelles's largest single GEF-funded project to date.

That framing is the interesting part, and also the part most likely to disappoint anyone who has watched enough donor-funded programmes in Seychelles promise integration and deliver a technical report instead. Seven years is a long implementation window, long enough to survive a change of tourism minister or two, which cuts both ways: it gives the programme room to actually shift decision-making culture, and it also gives it room to stall quietly once the inception-phase enthusiasm fades and the original team has moved on.

The project sits under the \$135.6 million GEF-8 Blue and Green Islands Integrated Programme, spanning 15 SIDS, which means Seychelles's implementation here is not just a domestic governance test, it is a reference case other SIDS environment ministries will be watching, whether or not anyone frames it that way publicly. Roughly 10,000 people, including coastal communities, are named as direct beneficiaries, a modest number for a \$10.48 million spend that should read as a strength: it signals the programme is trying to prove a governance model works at a size small enough to actually monitor, rather than chasing scale for its own sake.

The objection worth raising directly, because it is the one a funder or a peer would raise, is that integrate biodiversity conservation into decision-making is a phrase that can mean a training workshop and a policy brief nobody reads, or it can mean a mechanism with teeth. Whether this project lands on one side or the

other depends on whether it builds something concrete: a spatial planning tool, a natural capital accounting requirement written into tourism licensing, a mechanism with actual consequences rather than a capacity-building output that evaporates once the project closes. That is exactly the kind of implementation detail SHORE Institute's hydrospatial and spatial planning expertise is positioned to weigh in on, and it is worth requesting the project's actual theory of change document rather than working from the press release alone.

The stronger Shorelines piece here is a tracker, not a celebration of the \$10.48 million figure: naming the specific decision-making mechanisms this project commits to building in tourism, food, and urban planning, and returning to check whether they exist eighteen months from now. That kind of accountability piece is rare in Seychelles's donor-funded

programme coverage, and it is exactly the niche Shorelines can own.

<https://www.undp.org/mauritius-seychelles/news/undp-and-ministry-environment-sign-gef-8-project-advance-seychelles-blue-and-green-economy>

07

The high seas treaty's first real test is four months away

COP1 for the BBNJ Agreement is now fixed for January 2027, which means the institutional design choices you have been tracking since ratification are about to become permanent practice.

COP1 for the BBNJ Agreement is scheduled for 11 to 22 January 2027, one year almost to the day after the treaty entered into force on 17 January 2026 with 83 parties and 145 signatories. The third Preparatory Committee session, held 23 March to 2 April 2026, produced what the SDG Knowledge Hub called mixed progress on the institutional architecture: rules of procedure, the clearinghouse mechanism, and the financial mechanism are all still being negotiated rather than settled.

That four-month runway is the working window for anyone with a stake in how area-based management tools and marine protected area processes get operationalised in areas beyond national jurisdiction. Decisions made at PrepCom now become default practice at COP1, not draft language open for further negotiation.

<https://sdg.iisd.org/news/progress-mixed-as-countries-chart-course-for-bbnj-agreement-cop1/>

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TORY ARTICLE

A treaty entering into force is the easy part. The BBNJ Agreement cleared that bar on 17 January 2026, with 83 parties and 145 signatories, faster than most observers expected for an instrument covering two-thirds of the ocean. What happens between now and COP1, fixed for 11 to 22 January 2027, decides whether the agreement functions as intended or spends its first decade the way UNCLOS's own institutions did: technically operational, practically underused by the states that need them most.

The third Preparatory Committee session ran 23 March to 2 April 2026, and the SDG Knowledge Hub's own framing, progress mixed, is a diplomatic way of saying the hard questions are still open. Rules of procedure for the Conference of the Parties, the design of the clearinghouse mechanism meant to make environmental impact assessment data findable across jurisdictions, and the financial mechanism that determines whether capacity-constrained states can actually participate in area-based management proposals rather than just vote on them: none of these are settled.

This is the exact fault line the High-Income SIDS Paradox sits on, not a procedural technicality. Seychelles has the diplomatic standing to sit in these negotiating rooms and the institutional memory, from your own years as Director General for Maritime Boundary Delimitation, to know what a workable clearinghouse mechanism needs to look like operationally rather than on paper. What Seychelles does not automatically have, as a state whose high-income classification often excludes it from capacity-building funding tracks meant for SIDS, is the guaranteed seat at the technical table where these mechanisms get drafted.

Some negotiators argue that a slower PrepCom process produces a more durable institutional design, and that rushing rules of procedure to meet a COP1 date risks locking in mechanisms that do not survive contact with implementation. That is a fair point in the abstract. It is a weaker one in this specific case, because the financial mechanism design is where SIDS access gets decided, and every month it stays unresolved is a month where richer states with existing marine scientific research infrastructure get a head start on defining what area-based management tools look like in practice, before the states most affected by them have a formal say.

Four months is not long to influence a financial mechanism from the outside. It is enough time to write a Shorelines piece making the case for why COP1's financial architecture needs to explicitly account for high-income SIDS that fall through standard capacity-building eligibility screens, and to get that argument in front of the people drafting rules of procedure before January, not after.

See also: IOC-UNESCO, "BBNJ Agreement Successfully Ratified"; PrepCom3 summary report, 23 March to 2 April 2026.

<https://sdg.iisd.org/news/progress-mixed-as-countries-chart-course-for-bbnj-agreement-cop1/>

N ° 08

Ocean finance is still under one percent of climate finance

The Standing Committee on Finance is holding its first dedicated ocean finance forum this month, and the underfunding gap it is meant to address is the same one your work keeps running into when you try to cost hydrospatial monitoring into a climate proposal.

STORY NOTES

The UNFCCC Standing Committee on Finance is holding a forum dedicated to finance for water systems and ocean on 21 and 22 September, the first of its kind at this scale. The starting figure driving the agenda: ocean finance remains under one percent of total global climate finance, despite oceans covering seventy percent of the planet and SIDS depending on ocean-based sectors for the bulk of their economies.

AOSIS has used recent UNFCCC ocean and climate dialogues to push for a technology repository or information access centre built specifically for SIDS capacity constraints, arguing that the finance gap and the capacity gap are the same problem viewed from two sides.

https://unfccc.int/sites/default/files/resource/Ocean_Dialogue_2026_Information_Note.pdf

STORY ARTICLE

Less than one percent. That is the share of total global climate finance currently going to ocean-related action, a figure repeated at enough UNFCCC ocean and climate dialogues

this year that it has become the fixed opening line of every ocean finance panel, including the one the Standing Committee on Finance is convening for the first time as a dedicated forum on 21 and 22 September.

The gap is not a mystery. Ocean-based climate action sits awkwardly across mitigation and adaptation categories that most climate finance mechanisms were built around land-based sectors, and SIDS, whose economies and coastlines depend on the ocean more directly than almost any other state category, have spent years arguing that their NDCs carry ocean commitments conditional on finance nobody has committed to delivering. AOSIS's specific ask, a technology repository or information access centre built for SIDS capacity constraints, recognises that the finance gap and the capacity gap are functionally the same obstacle: even where ocean finance exists, SIDS often lack the technical capacity to access it competitively against larger states with dedicated climate finance units.

You have run into a version of this problem directly. Costing hydrospatial monitoring, seafloor mapping, coastal change detection,

marine spatial planning support, into a climate finance proposal is difficult precisely because most climate finance taxonomies have no clean category for spatial data infrastructure as climate adaptation. It gets filed under research, or capacity-building, both funded at a fraction of what infrastructure or mitigation categories receive, even when the spatial data in question is a prerequisite for any adaptation planning to happen at all.

The forum's format, a dedicated two-day session rather than a side event bolted onto a larger conference, is itself worth noting. Side events generate statements. A standing committee forum generates the kind of technical working paper that eventually feeds into how finance mechanisms get restructured, a slower process, but the one that actually changes what gets funded three or five years out.

The Shorelines angle here writes itself, and it is a stronger piece than a general lament about underfunding: name the specific taxonomy problem, that spatial data infrastructure has no clean climate finance category, with the SHORE Institute costing exercise as the concrete example, and argue for where in the existing mechanism architecture, the Adaptation Fund, GCF readiness support, a

spatial data infrastructure line item should sit. That is a proposal, not a complaint, and proposals get cited by people drafting the next finance mechanism review.

https://unfccc.int/sites/default/files/resource/Ocean_Dialogue_2026_Information_Note.pdf

09

Nineteen agreements, one blue economy question worth asking

India's nineteen bilateral outcomes with Seychelles include real blue economy and maritime capacity commitments, and the test of whether they mean anything is whether SHORE Institute or Seychelles's own institutions get named as implementation partners.

STORY NOTES

Prime Minister Modi's state visit to Seychelles, 27 to 29 June 2026, produced nineteen bilateral outcomes spanning development finance, digital payments, maritime cooperation, agriculture, and institutional capacity-building. Several of the outcomes touch blue economy cooperation directly, part of a broader pattern of India positioning itself as a maritime capacity partner across the Indian Ocean.

The open question, worth tracking rather than taking the announcement at face value, is implementation: which of the nineteen outcomes convert into funded programmes with named delivery institutions inside Seychelles, and which remain diplomatic language in a joint statement.

<https://www.orfonline.org/expert-speak/india-seychelles-relations-exploring-blue-economy-opportunities>

STORY ARTICLE

Nineteen bilateral outcomes from a single state visit is a lot of paper, and paper is exactly the right level of scepticism to bring to it. Prime Minister Modi's visit to Seychelles, 27 to 29 June, produced agreements spanning development finance, digital payments, maritime

cooperation, agriculture, and institutional capacity-building, several of which sit under the blue economy heading India has been building across its Indian Ocean relationships for several years now.

The pattern is bigger than Seychelles. India has been positioning itself as a maritime capacity partner across the region, hydrographic surveying support, coastal radar networks, and now blue economy cooperation frameworks with island states that have limited domestic capacity to build this infrastructure alone. Seychelles fits that pattern precisely: small state, strategically located, high-income enough to be an attractive partner rather than a pure aid recipient, and short on the kind of institutional capacity that turns a bilateral agreement into an operating programme.

That last point is the one worth pressing on, because it is where most bilateral cooperation announcements quietly fail. Nineteen outcomes signed in a joint statement is a diplomatic achievement. Nineteen funded work plans with named delivery institutions, timelines, and budget lines is a different achievement entirely, and the gap between the two is exactly where SHORE Institute's interest sits: if any of the maritime cooperation or blue economy outcomes involve spatial data, coastal monitoring, or mapping capacity, that is a partnership opening worth pursuing directly rather than waiting to see whether it materialises through official channels first.

The counterargument deserves a fair hearing: state-visit joint statements are inherently aspirational, a diplomatic wish list rather than an implementation roadmap, and reading too

much into any single line item risks chasing partnerships that were never meant to be operationalised on a specific timeline. That is often true. It is also not a reason to wait passively. The organisations that end up as implementation partners on these agreements are rarely the ones who wait for a tender to be announced. They are the ones who reach out early, name the specific technical capability they bring, and position themselves before the bureaucratic process for turning a joint statement into a funded programme even starts.

Worth a direct approach to Seychelles's Department of Blue Economy: which of the nineteen outcomes touch spatial data, mapping, or coastal monitoring, and is there a technical partner role for SHORE Institute before the implementation mechanism gets designed without local spatial science input at the table.

<https://www.orfonline.org/expert-speak/india-seychelles-relations-exploring-blue-economy-opportunities>

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The Blue Charter Incubator is about to reopen

The Commonwealth Blue Charter Project Incubator's next call opens mid-2026 with grants small enough for SHORE Institute to lead directly rather than compete for as a subcontractor, and the proposals that win are the ones already drafted before the call opens.

STORY NOTES

The Commonwealth Blue Charter Project Incubator, which funds ocean policy and project development activities with grants between £5,000 and £50,000, will reopen its call for proposals in mid-2026. Its last call closed in 2023, so this is the first opportunity in three years.

Grants at this size are small enough that SHORE Institute could lead a proposal directly rather than sit as a subcontractor under a larger institutional applicant, and the incubator's ocean policy and project development focus lines up closely with HARMONiSE framework development work.

<https://thecommonwealth.org/bluecharter/commonwealth-blue-charter-project-incubator>

STORY ARTICLE

Three years is a long gap between funding calls, and it is worth treating the Commonwealth Blue Charter Project Incubator's mid-2026 reopening as a genuine opportunity rather than a routine

grants announcement, precisely because the last call closed in 2023 and nobody currently active in Seychelles's ocean governance space has recent experience navigating this specific mechanism.

The incubator's grant band, £5,000 to £50,000, sits in a size range worth being deliberate about. It is too small to fund a multi-year institutional programme, and that is the point: it is designed for the development phase of an ocean policy idea, the stage where enough money to draft a methodology, run a pilot, or produce the technical groundwork that makes a larger funding application credible, not the stage where implementation is already at scale. That makes it a natural fit for early HARMONiSE framework development work, where the immediate need is proof-of-concept funding rather than a seven-figure implementation budget.

The size band also changes who can realistically lead the application. Larger ocean grants tend to require an institutional applicant with existing multi-year programme infrastructure, which usually means SHORE Institute would sit as a technical subcontractor under a UN agency or a larger NGO rather than as the named lead. A £5,000 to £50,000 grant is small enough that SHORE could credibly apply as the lead applicant, with Seychelles's own ocean governance work as the direct subject matter rather than a supporting role in someone else's regional programme.

The practical risk is timing: mid-2026 is not a fixed date, and Commonwealth funding announcements have a track record of slipping by months without much public warning. Waiting for the official call to open before starting to draft is the standard approach, and it is also how

most applicants lose the advantage a modest grant window like this rewards, being ready to submit in the first week rather than starting to think about the concept note after the call is already live.

The better approach, given the incubator funds project development rather than a novel-idea competition, is to have a concept note largely drafted now: what specific ocean policy or spatial planning gap the proposal addresses, what the £5,000 to £50,000 would concretely fund, and what larger funding application it is meant to set up. Contact bluecharter@commonwealth.int directly to confirm the reopening timeline rather than waiting for a public announcement, since Commonwealth Secretariat programme staff will often give an informal signal on timing to an organisation that reaches out with a specific, credible proposal already in hand.

<https://thecommonwealth.org/bluecharter/commonwealth-blue-charter-project-incubator>